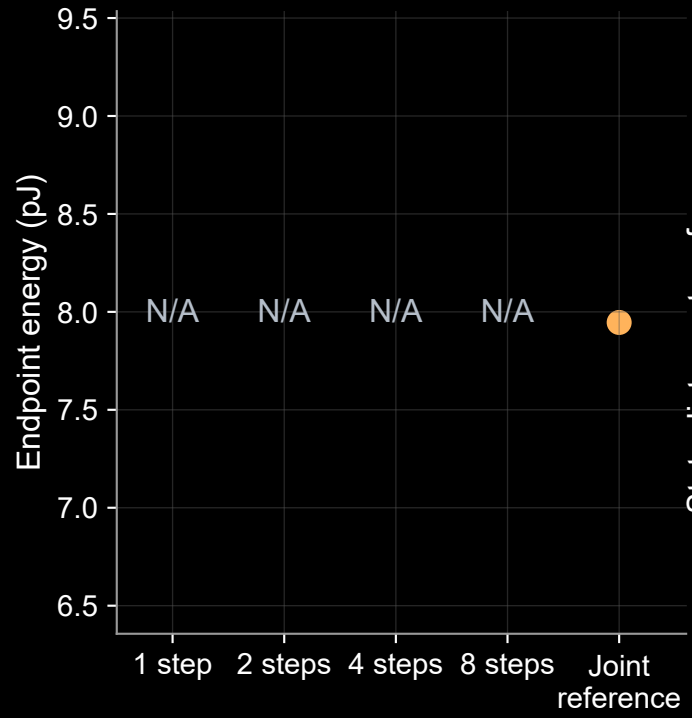
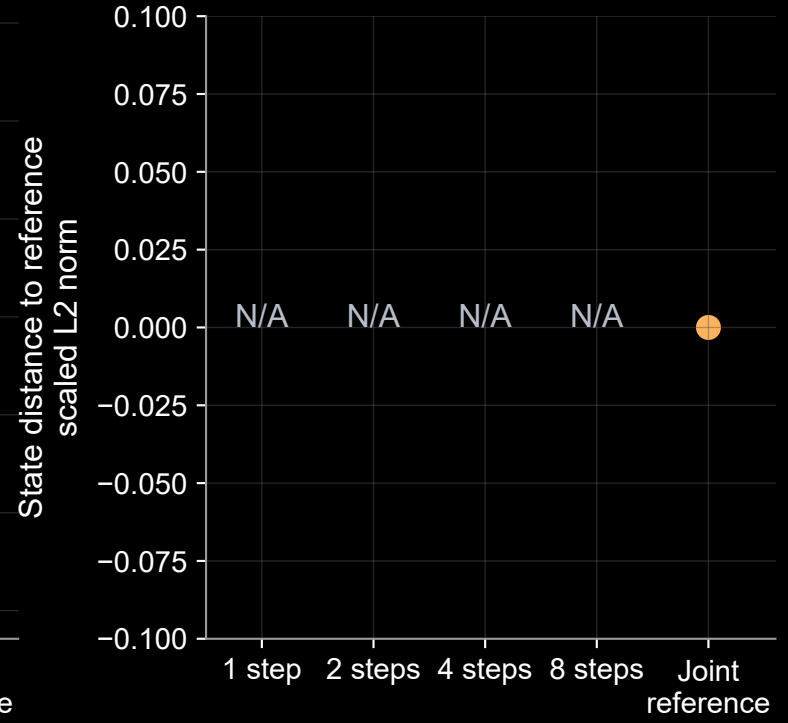
DIAGNOSTIC ONLY: no staggered path reaches the same endpoint

Target strain 0.014 | All subdivisions stop before accepting their first substep





N/A: endpoint state does not exist; partial states at different loads are not substituted
The joint reference is a stationary saddle, not a stable minimum. Its self-distance is zero
2 / 4 / 8 subdivisions attempt strain 0.0135 / 0.01325 / 0.013125; all hit the unchanged pure-tension gate